Orderly Notes

How an index makes a pile of field notes readable, with one chart, one photo and one table.

Why order matters

Field notes accumulate faster than anyone can file them. A good index turns that heap into something one can walk through. Each entry names a place, a date and the person who wrote it down. Cross references tie the entries together where the paper trail forks. Nothing here is new, but the order of things changes how they read. Readers who return after a week want to land exactly where they stopped. Field notes accumulate faster than anyone can file them. A good index turns that heap into something one can walk through. Each entry names a place, a date and the person who wrote it down.

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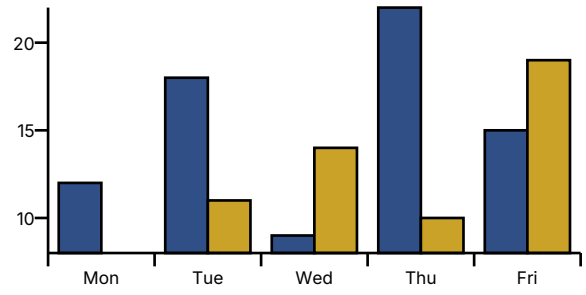

Figure 1: Notes filed per weekday, two seasons.

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Keeping place

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The column ends in the middle of this paragraph, which carries on in the next column Nothing here is new, but the order of things changes how they read. Readers who return after a week want to land exactly where they stopped. Field notes accumulate faster than anyone can file them. A good index turns that heap into something one can walk through. Each entry names a place, a date and the person who wrote it down. Cross references tie the entries together where the paper trail forks. Nothing here is new, but the order of things changes how they read. Readers who return after a week want to land exactly where they stopped. Field notes accumulate faster than anyone can file them. A good index turns that heap into something one can walk through. Each entry names a place, a date and the person who wrote it down. Cross references tie the entries together where the paper trail forks. Nothing here is new, but the order of things changes how they read. Readers who return after a week want to land exactly where they stopped.

Scanned Letter

Tessel recognizes scanned pages on this device.
Nothing is uploaded anywhere at all.

The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog.